Megan Fritts and Frank Cabrera “AI Recruitment Algorithms and the Dehumanization Problem”

The Rise of AI in Hiring

Growing Adoption

36% of HR professionals expect their company to heavily use AI for recruitment in the next two years

Key Applications

Sourcing candidates, screening resumes, conducting initial interviews, evaluating cultural fit

Promised Benefits

Finding more qualified candidates, reducing time spent reviewing resumes

Stages of AI-Assisted Hiring

Sourcing

AI conducts targeted searches to build initial candidate pool

Screening

AI processes resumes and predicts organizational fit

Interviewing

AI may conduct initial automated interviews

Selection

AI recommends top candidates from final pool

Current AI Recruitment Tools

Assessment Types

- Personality tests
- Situational judgment tests
- Puzzle-solving games
- Video interview analysis

Prediction Methods

Proprietary algorithms analyze candidate data and “training data” on past employees to predict future job success and performance

Potential Benefits of AI in Hiring

Efficiency

Faster screening of large candidate pools

Data-Driven

Decisions based on quantifiable metrics

Consistency

Standardized evaluation criteria

Reach

Ability to source candidates globally

The Future of AI in Hiring

Near-Term

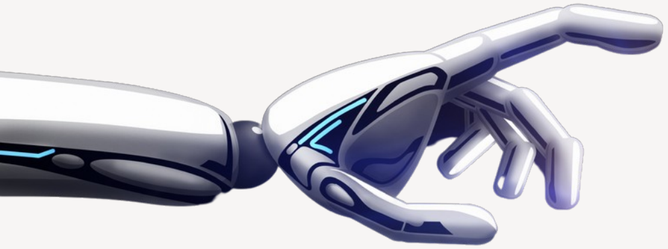
Increased adoption of AI for resume screening and initial interviews

Mid-Term

More sophisticated AI assessments of soft skills and cultural fit

Long-Term

Potential for AI to play significant role in final hiring decisions



The Dehumanization Concern

The most cited ethical concern about hiring algorithms is the “dehumanization of the recruitment process”

HR professionals worry that AI-based hiring will make recruitment lose its “human touch”. This concern is independent of issues of bias or discrimination.

Two Meanings of “Dehumanization”

Common Meaning

Conceiving of other humans as subhuman, often associated with human rights violations

Alternative Meaning

Removing the human presence from a process where it was previously taken as a given

The concern with AI hiring relates to the alternative meaning - leaving out humans.

Artificial Values in AI Recruitment

AI algorithms rely on artificial values created by programmers that only approximate human values. These artificial values have a clarity and simplicity that real human values lack.

Human Values

Complex, opaque, difficult to balance

AI Values

Artificially clear, quantifiable, easy to compare

The Ballet Dancer Scenario

Imagine a ballet dancer auditioning for the New York City Ballet, only to learn an AI will judge her performance instead of human judges.

Disadvantage

Less confident in ability to connect with AI vs. humans

Hollow Victory

Concern that being chosen by AI lacks depth of human appreciation for her skill and performance

Artificial Clarity

AI imposes artificial clarity on complex human values. This is dehumanizing.

The Employee-Employer Relationship

Stakeholder Theory

Corporations have obligations to all stakeholders, including employees, not just shareholders

Distinct Social Relationship

Employee-employer relationships have unique behavioral norms and privacy standards

Applicant Relationship

Employers also have a relationship with job applicants that could be impacted by AI hiring

The Sorry State of Employee-Employer Relations

Adversarial

Many workers feel at odds with management

Distrust

Only 50% of workers believe employers are “open and upfront”

Tension

Lack of unity and commitment to mutual well-being

The Human Touch vs. Objectivity

Avoiding dehumanization in hiring may come at the expense of objectivity or impartiality. The human capacity to be moved by others is also what allows bias to enter.

Human Judges

Capable of being deeply moved, but susceptible to bias

AI Judges

More objective, but may miss intangible human qualities

Tradeoffs

Balancing human touch and fairness may require case-by-case decisions

Ethical Frameworks for AI Hiring

Respect for Persons

Foundational principle across ethical theories

Stakeholder Consideration

Account for impacts on all affected parties

Bias Mitigation

Strive for fairness while preserving human element

Transparency

Clear communication about AI use in hiring

Balancing AI and Human Touch

Hybrid Approaches

Combine AI efficiency with human judgment in key stages

Ethical Guidelines

Develop clear principles for AI use in hiring

Candidate Experience

Ensure applicants feel valued and respected throughout the process